Stein's Recording Angel – Miss F. M. G. Lorimer

HELEN WANG

In the Introductions to the Full Reports of his expeditions to Chinese Central Asia,[1] Sir Aurel Stein (1862–1943), professional as always, was careful to acknowledge the assistance of all involved with the production of the reports. Most of his colleagues in the academic world were men who to this day retain their positions as great scholars in the history of oriental studies. The people who helped Stein in the remote sites of Xinjiang live on through his affectionate, and often humorous, descriptions of them scattered throughout the Full Reports and the popular abridged accounts of his expeditions. Yet very little is known of the people who worked on a day-to-day basis with Stein, unpacking the many cases he sent to the British Museum, sorting through the various groups of often unfamiliar material, documenting the Stein collection, arranging exhibitions of objects and photographs relating to Stein's expeditions, as well as carrying out personal favours for Stein, such as posting on his spats and packing tea tablets bought on his account at the Army and Navy Store.[2] Even "the caves", the dingy basements of the British Museum,[3] are better known than these people!

The "Recording Angel"

In the case of Miss F. M. G. Lorimer, her contribution to the Stein collection is acknowledged in a few publications, namely in *Serindia* and *Innermost Asia*, the long reports

I would like to thank the Lorimer family for their support in the preparation of this paper. I would also like to thank W. H. Clennell (Bodleian Library), Mrs G. M. Goudge (RHS Library), Paula Lucas (Royal Geographical Society), Miss F. M. Foster (Dundee Libraries), Ian Flett (Archives and Records Centre, Dundee), Mr Thackeray (Society for the History of Natural History), Mrs Patullo (Dundee High School), Pauline Adams (Somerville College), Seth Cardew (Wenford Bridge Pottery), Helen Barnett, Lorna Poole (John Lewis Partnership) and Professor W. T. Stearn.

[1] M. Aurel Stein (1907) *Ancient Khotan: Detailed Report of Archaeological Explorations in Chinese Turkestan*, 2 vols, Oxford; (1921) *Serindia: Detailed Report of Explorations in Central Asia and Westernmost China*, 5 vols, Oxford; (1928) *Innermost Asia: Detailed Report of Exploration in Central Asia, Kansu and Eastern Iran*, 4 vols, Oxford.

[2] Stein's instructions for the personal favours could be as detailed as his work favours. Whilst in Europe, Stein had arranged for "a pound of compressed Indian tea in tablets which I am ordering to be sent to you by A&N Stores from my account." [Bodleian Stein MS 37:177, Stein to Andrews, 27-08-09) The following day Stein again wrote to Andrews: "The tea, if it comes, could best be sent to me by instalments packed *bookpost fashion* and marked *sample without value*. The tablets pack flat & 5–6 in each packet (open at end) will pass unmolested, anyhow while I am in Austria. The spats, too, could go by sample post, each at a time, rolled up in plenty of paper." (Bodleian Stein MS 37:179 Stein to Andrews, 28-08-09)

[3] See Peter Hopkirk's *Foreign Devils on the Silk Road: the Search for the Lost Cities and Treasures of Chinese Central Asia* (1980). Stein also refers to the British Museum as the "beehive": "Please do not trouble to write me a letter. Just jot down on a slip any communication needed, as if I were in another cellar or cell of that B.M. beehive, and post it." (Bodleian Stein MS 37:192 Stein to Andrews, 09-09-09)

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from Stein's Second and Third Expeditions, respectively, and in the catalogue of the 1914 exhibition in the British Museum of objects acquired by Stein during his second expedition.

This exhibition was the first major display of material from the Stein collection, and "in arranging it, the officers of the British Museum have had the constant co-operation of Sir A. Stein's assistants, Mr F. H. Andrews and Miss F. Lorimer." The exhibition was "designed to show the most valuable results of the second journey of archaeological and geographical investigation carried out by Sir Marc Aurel Stein, K.C.I.E., in Chinese Turkestan and the adjoining western border of China, under the joint auspices of the Government of India and the Trustees of the British Museum." Another purpose of the exhibition was to "put before the public characteristic examples of the various classes of objects before they are allotted to their final destinations." The final destinations would depend upon the British Museum and the Government of India which had jointly funded the Second Expedition. The objects were displayed in the newly opened King Edward VII Gallery,[4] beginning at the eastern side of the gallery, with the paintings filling the cases along the entire northern side. The small finds were displayed along the southern side of the gallery, and the exhibition ended with a display of the manuscripts. The catalogue, *Guide to an Exhibition of Paintings, Manuscripts, and other Archaeological Objects collected by Sir Aurel Stein, K.C.I.E., in Chinese Turkestan*, cost four pence.

Stein mentions Miss Lorimer four times in the Reports concerning his Second and Third Expeditions. In the Introduction to *Serindia*, the report of the Second Expedition, Stein writes:

> The most important and urgent of those tasks [connected with the collection and the preparation of the Report] was the preparation of full Descriptive Lists of all classes of antiquities in the collection, arranged according to sites. It would have been impossible to assure this within any reasonable limits of time had not liberal provision made by the India Office authorities allowed advantage to be taken of the trained help and scholarly zeal of several young classical archaeologists, Mr J. P. Droop,[5], Miss F. M. G. Lorimer, Mr C. L. Woolley,[6] and for an initial period, also Mr H. G. Evelyn-White, who conjointly or successively have filled the posts of assistants at my collection for over two years. My grateful acknowledgements are due to them all, but in particular to Miss Lorimer and Mr Woolley ...
>
> Miss Lorimer continued her zealous and painstaking work as assistant also subsequently and rendered very valuable help with regard to the temporary exhibition which, arranged in 1914 in the newly opened north galleries of the British Museum, made characteristic portions of the whole collection accessible to the public for some months ... To Miss Lorimer I am specially indebted also for most of the detailed descriptions of the pictorial remains from the 'Thousand Buddhas', ...[7]

> This Descriptive List [of Paintings, Woodcuts, Textiles, and miscellaneous antiques recovered from Ch'ien-fo-tung], ... has been prepared mainly by the hand of Miss Lorimer, whose devoted help over this task I cannot value too highly.[8]

[4] Renamed in 1992 as the Joseph E. Hotung Gallery of Oriental Art.
[5] John Percival Droop (1882–1963).
[6] Sir Charles Leonard Woolley (1880–1960).
[7] Introduction to *Serindia*, p. xiv.
[8] *Serindia*, p. 835.

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The designs [of the Chi'en-fo-tung fabrics] received special attention also in the detailed notes on individual fabrics which my artist collaborator and Miss Lorimer prepared for the Descriptive List. Besides contributing many of the entries concerning our decorated fabrics from Ch'ien-fo-tung, Miss Lorimer has also offered very valuable help by recording detailed references to certain decorative motifs familiar from 'Sassanian' and other early textile remains of the West, with which some of the designs represented among our fabrics are manifestly connected.[9]

In the Introduction to *Innermost Asia*, the report of the Third Expedition, Stein writes:

This collection ... will be housed at the New Delhi capital, excepting representative specimens to be presented to the British Museum. Reference to the originals will therefore not be practicable, except in rare cases, ... This consideration rendered it all the more important that all entries in the Descriptive Lists should be exact and adequately detailed. For this purpose Mr Andrews[10] was provided with the assistance of Miss F. M. G. Lorimer, who, as one of my assistants engaged on the objects collected in the course of my second expedition, had acquired ample experience in dealing with Central-Asian antiquities. The efficient help rendered by her at Srinagar during the years 1919–1922 proved once again of considerable value.[11]

The Inventory List of coins [found or obtained during Stein's Third Expedition] in Appendix B has been prepared from notes which Miss F. M. G. Lorimer had compiled with much care.[12]

Stein maintained a regular correspondence with his colleagues and friends, and letters to his chief assistant, Mr Andrews, tell of her first weeks on the Stein collection:

Now that the wall cases are available would it not be possible to start his [Evelyn-White's] successor [Droop] on a series of greater archaeol. interest & variety? say miscell. objects from Yotkan, Khadalik, Niya or L.A.? I think a certain amount of prelimin. unpacking would be advisable & would stimulate the new assistants' [Droop and Lorimer] interest & help them to realize the scope & variety of the work before them.[13]

As things are, the best course is for you to guide Droop and Miss L. by the light of your own experience & keenness & leave to *them* as much of the drudgery as you possibly can, and to reserve for yourself the really novel tasks, such as the silks and large frescoes.[14]

There have been two biographies of Sir Aurel Stein.[15] Jeanette Mirsky's biography quotes extensively from the Stein archives at the Bodleian Library, Oxford, and Annabel Walker has produced a narrative of Stein's life, filling in much of the contemporary background. Both mention Miss Lorimer, but only briefly. Mirsky writes:

Madam [Mary Helen Allen][16] had recommended her [Miss Lorimer] as a valuable addition, and her sobriquet [Recording Angel] indicates that she quickly became part of the inner circle; she continued

[9] *Serindia*, p. 902.

[10] Frederick Henry Andrews (1866–1957), see obituary in the *Journal of the Royal Society of Arts*, December 1957.

[11] Introduction to *Innermost Asia*, p. xv.

[12] *Innermost Asia*, Introduction pp. xviii–xix, Appendix B, pp. 989–95.

[13] Bodleian Stein MS 37:216 Stein to Andrews 24-10-09. Corrected text of the version quoted in Jeanette Mirsky: *Sir Aurel Stein Archaeological Explorer.* (Chicago, 1977), p. 341.

[14] Bodleian Stein MS 37:225 Stein to Andrews 20-11-09. Corrected text of the version quoted in Mirsky, p. 341.

[15] Mirsky (op. cit.); Annabel Walker: *Aurel Stein, Pioneer of the Silk Road* (1995).

[16] M. H. Allen was a close friend of Stein's, and wife of Percy Stafford Allen, see fn 32 below.

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her role when she moved to India, and then, after many years, when she exchanged roles, she disappears from Stein's letters; she married. Through her full and precise notes, made in duplicate and sent weekly to Stein, he could follow the progress being made in 'the caves'.[17]

Miss Lorimer may have disappeared from Stein's letters, but later she reappears in the academic world of Central Asia, after many years of a varied career in both the commercial and academic worlds.

Who was Miss Lorimer?

Florence Mary Glen Lorimer was born on December 11th 1883 in the Free Church Manse of Strathmartine, near Dundee. Her father, the Revd Robert Lorimer (1840–1925), was a well-known minister of the Free Church of Scotland and author of a number of books.[18] Her mother, Isabella Lockhart Lorimer (née Robertson)[19] (1849–1931), had a formidable reputation: she was a strong woman, ambitious for her children and later renowned for her work with the poor. She was so well-liked for helping people living in tenements to get hospital treatment, that she was the only person able to walk unaccompanied by police escort through the back streets of Dundee (when even the police only went in pairs).[20]

Miss Lorimer was educated at Dundee High School, then at Notting Hill High School, and not only took up a place at Somerville College, Oxford, but did so as the Gilchrist Scholar of 1902.[21] She was one of only seventy four students in Somerville that year, when the total number of women at Oxford University for the year 1902–3 was only 228, and women were not considered as full members of the University. It was only eighteen years later, in 1920, that women became members of the University; prior to 1920 they were registered instead with the Association for Promoting the Higher Education of Women. It was also in 1902 that Emmeline Pankhurst founded the Suffragette Movement.

Miss Lorimer left Oxford in 1905 with Hon. Moderations, Classics, Class 3 – a lower degree than might have been expected from a scholar, but quite a common class of degree for graduates of her year.[22] She may have felt the pressures of her family's religious and academic background. Her three older siblings had certainly lived up to their mother's expectations. During Miss Lorimer's first year at Oxford, her oldest brother, Gordon (John Gordon Lorimer [1870–1914]), was made a Commander [of the Order] of the Indian Empire.[23] During her second year, the second brother, Lock (David Lockhart Robertson Lorimer [1876–1962]), was promoted to the Political Department of the Government of

[17] Mirsky, p. 340.

[18] His publications include *Mains and Strathmartine United Free Church: a Short Historical and Architectural Account* (1909); see also J. A. Lamb's *Fasti of the United Free Church of Scotland 1900–1929* (1956). Details of the earlier Lorimer family can be found in R. L. C. Lorimer's Introduction to his father's *The New Testament in Scots* (1983).

[19] Daughter of David Robertson H.E.I.C. (1811–57), judge at Bareilly, India, and hanged in 1857 by his own servants during the Indian Mutiny. See R. L. C. Lorimer (1983), p. ix.

[20] Author's communication with R. L. C. Lorimer, grandson of Robert and Isabella Lorimer. Isabella Lorimer's work with the poor is confirmed by her obituary (no source, no date) held in the Dundee Archives. See also R. L. C. Lorimer (1983), Introduction.

[21] Somerville College Archives: the scholarship was worth £50 for three years.

[22] This suggests that she completed the first two years of a degree. Examinations were taken after the first two years study of language and literature (Mods) and after another two years study of history and philology (Greats).

[23] *Who was Who, 1897–1915*. His publications include *Lorimer's Gazetteer of the Persian Gulf, Oman and Arabistan* (1915), published posthumously.

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Miss F. M. G. Lorimer, c.1916 (Courtesy of Mr R. L. C. Lorimer)

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India, and was British Vice-Consul in Arabistan.[24] Her sister, Elizabeth Hilda Lockhart Lorimer (1873–1953), was none other than the Classics Tutor at Somerville since 1896.[25]

Miss Lorimer had four other siblings. Her twin brother, Charlie (Charles 1883–?), emigrated to Canada. Emily (Emilia 1882–1953?) was a poet.[26] Her brother, William Laughton Lorimer (1885–1967), was Professor of Greek at University College Dundee and the University of St Andrews, and is famous for his translation of the *New Testament* from Greek into Scots, published after his death.[27] The youngest of the family was Bertie (Robert Campbell Lorimer [1886–1975]), who is said to have resigned from the Indian police outraged by the imprisonment of an Indian princess, yet later returned to India to teach mathematics. His ardent campaigning continued (against the Vietnam War, vivisection, nuclear weapons) and he was being arrested even in his early eighties.[28]

It is clear, then, that Miss Lorimer came from a family of extremely intelligent and strong-minded people. Most of her siblings were highly successful in their careers, and in her own career, she was often one of the first women to be employed in posts traditionally held by men.

In 1907, two years after graduation, Miss Lorimer was engaged by Mr E. B. Nicholson (1882–1912) of the Bodleian Library, to work on the revision of the catalogue. Nicholson was one of the first librarians to encourage the Bodleian to employ women, and she was trained by Mr Strickland Gibson.[29] She stayed at the Bodleian until 1909 when she became, in her own words, "Assistant to Sir Aurel Stein".[30] From the Stein papers, now housed at the Bodleian, it is clear that Miss Lorimer was quite a find.

Miss Lorimer's work on the Stein collection in London and Kashmir

Miss Lorimer's appointment replaced the first assistant on the Stein collection, Miss McDonald, who had been employed "to render clerical and other assistance as heretofore in connection with the work on Dr Stein's collection at a weekly remuneration of two pounds, ten shillings, the week being reckoned to include one Sunday and one half holiday from 2pm." These details of employment had apparently been drawn up at Miss

[24] D. L. R. Lorimer was a close friend of Stein's; see correspondence in the Bodleian Library, Oxford. He and his wife, Emily Overend Lorimer [1881–1949] were well-known figures in the field of Asian studies, winning the Triennial Burton Memorial Medal from the Royal Asiatic Society in 1948. His numerous publications include *Syntax of Colloquial Pashtu* (1915) and *The Burushaski Language*, 3 vols (1935–8). See *Who was Who, 1961–70*). E. O. Lorimer (daughter of Judge T. G. Overend) was Tutor in Germanic Philology at Somerville College, Oxford (1907–10); her publications include *What Hitler wants* (1939) and *Language Hunting in the Karakoram* (1939). (See *Who was Who, 1941–50*.)

[25] Her publications include *Homer and the Monuments* (1950) as well as books on Serbian history.

[26] Emilia Lorimer: *Songs of Alban* (1912). She married Dr Kenneth Williamson, a biologist who assisted Sir Ronald Ross in his research on malaria.

[27] For biographical details, see R. L. C. Lorimer's Introduction to *The New Testament in Scots*, also K. J. Dover "William Laughton Lorimer [1885–1967]", Memoir printed in the British Academy's *Proceedings*, Vol. LIII, pp. 437–88. R. L. C. Lorimer edited his father's work, set up the W. L. Lorimer Memorial Trust and himself translated *Macbeth* into Scots (1942).

[28] Author's conversation with R. L. C. Lorimer.

[29] Sir Edmund Craster, *History of the Bodleian Library 1845–1945* (1952); Bodleian Archives: Lorimer to Stein 18-01-40.

[30] Correspondence Cardew to Gibson 18-01-40.

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Back row from left: Hilda Lorimer, Gordon Lorimer, Emilia Lorimer.
Centre row from left: David Robertson, Isabella Lorimer, Robert Lorimer.
Front row from left: Charles Lorimer, Florence Lorimer.
(Courtesy of Mrs J. Dunlop)

McDonald's request.[31] McDonald irritated Stein, who thought she was not committed to the work, and who had clearly kept his eye on Miss Lorimer as an alternative:

I cannot help feeling annoyed by the tone adopted and especially when I remember that it was she [McDonald] who had repeatedly asked for employment before my return.

To tell you frankly, I have grave doubts whether with the attitude she has adopted a satisfactory co-operation can be expected in future ...

The enclosed draft conditions will show Miss M. that we are prepared to go as far as possible, but that we must keep our hands free for a change whenever it may seem desirable. The rest will depend on her. Miss Lorimer would have been quite ready to join on £120 per annum & she would have brought professional knowledge, – a very important factor if by any chance White would leave us due to ill-health, etc. – if Miss M. refuses to accept the conditions which meet all her demands but

[31] Bodleian Stein MS 37:167 Stein to Andrews 18-08-09. Details of employment attached to letter.

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emphasise the right we possess, *in any case*, of dispensing with her services when this seems fit, the best plan would be to pay her for a proportionable holiday & to let her know that she need not rejoin after it.

I am asking Publius [Percy Stafford Allan] about Miss Lorimer just to be on the safe side ...[32]

Nine days later, Stein writes again to Andrews:

I am glad Miss M. has signed my conditions. I have no objection to her slight modifications & also quite approve of your letting her take her holiday in September, I suppose from the 1st. Please get her to state *in writing* where letters can reach her during her absence from work.

I think this important because a variety of considerations suggest to me that it would be wise for us to discuss her eventual replacement by some one who would have a scholarly and artistic interest in the work, not purely a commercial one. I quite appreciate her good points, but am also convinced that for £130 a year we could secure far more intelligent help from a lady like Miss Lorimer. I enclose Publius' letter concerning her.[33]

However, Miss McDonald was not the only staff problem at the Stein Collection. On August 25th, Andrews informed Stein that his first assistant White was leaving to take up a Head Mastership,[34] and on September 5th he wrote to tell Stein that "E-W [Evelyn-White] has been offered the opportunity of an expedition to Libya on rather good terms."[35] Within four days, Stein wrote back to Andrews, estimating that "White should be getting to Kharga [Egypt] by Nov 1st", and that Andrews should now devote himself to getting a new assistant:

So the only course open seems for you to write *at once* to Drop (or whatever Dr Hogarth's [at Magdalen College] candidate calls himself) & offer the post of assistant on £200 per annum from the end of Sept. or whenever White leaves ...

White's departure & the possibility of D. not being available or giving up the work after a time illustrates what I wrote about the advantage of having a second Asst. like Miss Lorimer, interested in the tasks and capable of handing on scholarly knowledge about them. You did not refer in reply to what I wrote from Karlsbad, no doubt as the matter had no immediate urgency – Perhaps, you could kindly look up my former letter and ascertain from Publius what they have learned about her plans. My idea would be to engage Miss L. say from Nov. 1st, in place of Miss M. on £120 per annum, & to let her acquire a practical acquaintance with the collection by taking a share in cataloguing. She could for half the day make her own slips (at once typed) and for the other do copying work for you & the 1st Asst. If later on our 1st Asst. (Drop?) would leave us as Wh. does now, Miss L. would be fit to step in, & we should not find ourselves temporarily stranded. Thus complete interruption of the work would be guarded against. To Miss M. the whole case could be fully explained in this (true) aspect. Please do think this second matter over & put yourself into communication with Publius as you think fit. He knows all the circumstances & could easily get into touch with Miss Lorimer. Perhaps an interview with her could be arranged. Of course, *she* ought not to be told about a possible chance of subsequent promotion.[36]

[32] Bodleian Stein MS 37:168 Stein to Andrews 18-08-09. Percy Stafford Allan (1869–1933) was a Fellow of Merton College, Oxford, in 1909. He was later Curator of the Bodleian Library (1913–33), Curator of the Indian Institute (1914–25), and the President of Corpus Christi College, Oxford, from 1924. See *Who was Who, 1929–40*.

[33] Bodleian Stein MS 37:172 Stein to Andrews 27-08-09.

[34] Bodleian Stein MS 37:170 Andrews to Stein 25-08-09.

[35] Bodleian Stein MS 37:185 Stein to Andrews 05-09-09.

[36] Bodleian Stein MS 37:192 Stein to Andrews 09-09-09.

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In the end, White decided not to go to Egypt, preferring instead to acquire extensive knowledge and experience by working with Stein. But, wrote Stein:

White's decision to remain makes it easier, as you say yourself, to provide for her [Miss McDonald's] replacement by Miss Lorimer ... When your visits to the Museum must be less frequent than hitherto, it is doubly desirable that there should be a second competent person to help in cataloguing. Miss McD. if she remains for years longer will never acquire the competence from want of necessary education & training. Miss Lorimer may after a few weeks help White efficiently in cataloguing. Miss McD.'s purely commercial attitude relieves us of any special obligation & she has accepted the sufficiency of one month's notice. I do not know whether since Publius last wrote you have communicated with him about Miss Lorimer. But I fear, further delay may cause a loss of her help. Publius knows fully what is aimed at as I wrote to him repeatedly on the subject. If Miss L. can be secured at the close of Miss M.'s month of notice it would be the best arrangement.

Miss L. would have to be offered the same terms as already explained: £120 per annum; one month's leave on full pay for every 11 months; usual official holidays; daily working time 10 a.m.–5 p.m., with half holiday on Saturday. But in case Publius thinks this advisable I should be prepared to hold out the hope of £150 salary per annum in case after two months' probation she proves *in your opinion* fully competent for cataloguing work. In case these additional £30 (to count from date after probation) could not be obtained from I.O. [India Office], I should hold myself personally responsible for them.[37]

On October 2nd, Andrews wrote to tell Stein:

I saw Miss McDonald yesterday at the BM and had a chat with her about her prospects. Her brother returns to Cyprus in a fortnight's time, & it is possible Miss McD. may find it best to accompany him! I am doing my utmost to avoid anything like unpleasantness, using such diplomacy as I have. I have said nothing to her about any successor, & I think the change will come about quite pleasantly.[38]

Stein was delighted:

Of course, I leave all arrangements entirely in your hands [at Andrews' request] & shall not breathe a word to Miss M. about my knowledge of her intention – and how it suits us.

I only wish Miss Lorimer may still be available & ready to take up the work on the conditions I indicated in my letter about this. I trust you have kindly sent it on to Publius.[39]

Miss McDonald handed in her notice and Andrews set about engaging Miss Lorimer to work on the Stein collection:

Miss McD. has asked to be released at the end of present week as she has a chance of proceeding to Cyprus. I have granted her request, & hope you will approve. Miss L. comes to see me tomorrow to arrange about taking up the work.[40]

I saw Miss Lorimer on Thursday and arranged that she should begin work on Tuesday next. She has been given to understand that the work will last for two years, & I told her I believed it would. Publius will of course write to you all that he has done in the matter.[41]

[37] Bodleian Stein MS 37:196 Stein to Andrews 26-09-09.
[38] Bodleian Stein MS 37:201 Andrews to Stein 02-10-09.
[39] Bodleian Stein MS 37:202 Stein to Andrews 06-10-09.
[40] Bodleian Stein MS 37:204 Andrews to Stein 06-10-09.
[41] Bodleian Stein MS 37:207 Andrews to Stein 10-10-09.

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At last Stein had Miss Lorimer working on his collection:

Many & hearty thanks for your most welcome letter of the 10th. I am *very* glad that Miss Lorimer is secured and that the *changement de décoration* has been effected so pleasantly. It was your diplomacy, dear friend, which did it. I enclose Miss M.'s farewell note which please destroy, as well as her letter of resignation, for record.

I hope Miss L. will settle down intelligently to the work & earn *your* approval. If you can send me some news thereafter, perhaps, you can let me know of your first impressions & whether you could give her some catalogue work to try her hand on.[42]

Miss Lorimer started work on the Stein Collection at the British Museum in mid-October 1909.[43] She, and the newly appointed Mr Droop, settled in well. Within a month Andrews was writing to Stein:

The catalogue is growing in the hands of Droop & Miss Lorimer, & the material being dealt with is more varied than before ... As soon as Droop came in, I put him on to L.A., L.B. [Lop sites], and Miss L. to such things as I thought might be best, given her want of experience. I am (I hope) developing their keenness in the work, by varying the materials occasionally, and an occasional bout of unpacking. Miss L. is not as quick with the typing as Miss McD., but she will acquire greater speed no doubt. Her own slips are generally good, and will be quite satisfactory after more experience. Both Miss L. and Droop are energetic and 'alive', and it is delightful to have this quality about one.[44]

Miss Lorimer was exactly what Stein had hoped she would be, and on December 1st, Stein wrote to Andrews about increasing her salary:

I think his [Holderness] invitation to see him about any special requirement ought to be acted upon in regard to Miss L.'s salary which was to be raised to £150 per annum after her two months' probation. I have made myself permanently responsible for the excess over the £120 so far budgetted, but that is no reason why we should not get the I.O. to pay for the additional value received in her services. The best plan would be for you to see Sir T.H. [Holderness] within the next fortnight & to explain that on Miss McD's leaving you had at my strong recommendation engaged Miss L. to help not only as typist & ammanuensis but also as a qualified scientific assistant. You must lay stress on her archaeological training under Prof. Gardner, her Oxford degree exam., & the increased progress in cataloguing secured by her aid. £30 per annum is a small sacrifice for the time & labour thus saved, & as she has given full satisfaction you propose that provision be made to raise her salary from £120 available to £150. You need *not* make any reference to my personal guarantee in the matter. I do not think that great difficulty will be made about this extra cost, slight after all in comparison, if only you represent it as a matter dependent on the I.O. approval & not as a *fait accompli*! After explaining the matter verbally you will have to apply in a *brief* official letter – stating Miss L.'s superior scholarly qualifications, etc.[45]

From January 1909 to December 1911 Stein was in Europe, on leave and working at the British Museum on the new collection of antiquities acquired on his Second Expedition. By 1913 Stein had set out on his Third Expedition to Chinese Turkestan[46] and Andrews

[42] Bodleian Stein MS 37:208 Stein to Andrews 13-10-09.
[43] Bodleian Stein MS 37:207 Andrews to Stein 10-10-09; MS 37:208 Stein to Andrews 13-10-09.
[44] Bodleian Stein MS 37:219 Andrews to Stein 14-11-09.
[45] Bodleian Stein MS 37:231 Stein to Andrews 10-12-09.
[46] Stein uses a different term in each of his major publications to describe the region known by its political name in his time as Sinkiang (Xinjiang) Province (1884–1955) and since 1955 as The Xinjiang Uighur Autonomous Region of the People's Republic of China.

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had moved out to Kashmir to become Director of the new Technical Institute.[47] Miss Lorimer continued her work on the Stein collection in the British Museum, communicating with Stein by sending succinct weekly progress reports halfway round the world.[48] Only one short letter strays from the professional into the personal: in February 1914 she writes from her address at Cliveden Place, Sloane Square (instead of her usual address: The Stein Collection, British Museum)[49] that her elder brother Gordon had been killed. He had transferred from Baghdad to Bushire in November 1913 to take over from Sir Percy Cox for one year or more.[50] The eldest son of this Scottish family, with his phenomenal career in the Foreign Office, left behind a wife and two small daughters.[51]

Miss Lorimer's own career in the British Museum had been more uncertain:

> ... I do know however that I am not to stay on here beyond the end of the year [1914]; he [Director] wants to put the Newspapers in; and he has vaguely promised Mr Drake that I shall be no worse off than before, so I suppose I am returning to the cellars. I shall be sorry; but glad not to be turned out altogether.[52]

By 1915, there was some suggestion that Miss Lorimer might move to Kashmir to work on the Collection from Stein's Third Expedition:

> As to the possible cataloguing of it out there, I should like to say that I should awfully enjoy working out there, if that is the arrangement finally adopted. I could not speak quite definitely at first owing to some personal circumstances, which have now cleared themselves up!
>
> But in any case it would have been very difficult to lose any chance of seeing Kashmir.[53]

Despite her enthusiasm to go to Kashmir, she remained in the British Museum, and in 1917 Miss Lorimer's brother, Lock, wrote to Stein: "I am very glad my sister got an extension with the BM at Home ...[54]

In November 1919 Miss Lorimer eventually moved to Kashmir to join Stein and Andrews who were working on the Stein Collection there. The weekly letters exchanged between Stein and his friend, Percy Stafford Allen (1869–1933),[55] reveal how much Stein was looking forward to introducing Miss Lorimer to his beloved Kashmir and to having the Stein team working together on the Collection of objects from his Third Expedition:

[47] Walker p. 206, p. 240.

[48] For the correspondence between Stein and Lorimer 1912–15, detailing the progress being made in the British Museum on the Stein collection from the Second Expedition, see E. Diamond and T. D. Rogers (1983) *Catalogue of the Papers of Sir (Marc) Aurel Stein (1862–1943)*. These papers were bequeathed by Stein to the Indian Institute, now in the Bodleian Library, Oxford.

[49] The RAS List of Members gives the following addresses for Miss Lorimer from 1915–32: The Stein Collection (1915–20); c/o Postmaster, Srinagar, Kashmir (1921–2); c/o Lloyds Bank Ltd, 9 Pall Mall, London SW1 (1932) (this was also Stein's bank, see R. G. S. Stein Correspondence Block 1921–30 Stein to Hinks 12-11-25); 47 Barkston Gardens, Earls Court, London SW5 (1924–6); 11 Courtfield Road, London SW1 (1927); 19 Holland Street, London W8 (1928); 4 North View, Wimbledon Common, London SW19 (1929–32).

[50] Bodleian Stein MS 94:147 Lorimer to Stein 11-02-14. The move to Bushire had marked a significant promotion for J. G. Lorimer. Major-General Sir Percy Cox was Political Resident in the Persian Gulf (1909–14), and Lorimer replaced him when Cox was made Chief Political Officer of the Indian Expeditionary Force "D" (G.C.I.E.) (1914–18).

[51] His widow and daughters, Jean and Dorothy, returned to live in Scotland for one year and then in England.

[52] Bodleian Stein MS 94:194 Lorimer to Stein 06-11-14.

[53] Bodleian Stein MS 94:221 Lorimer to Stein 22-04-15.

[54] Bodleian Stein MS 15:87 D. L. R. Lorimer to Stein 11-12-17.

[55] *Who was Who, 1929–40*.

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The enclosed telegram reporting the R.A.'s [the Recording Angel, Miss Lorimer] safe arrival was a real relief; for after months of discussions & 'ways & means' with the Barons [Mr and Mrs F. Andrews], of writing and telegraphing since the end of December, I had become somewhat doubtful as to when the great move might be achieved. All's well that ends well; but it would have saved me a week or two of working time if the R.A. had only let us know beforehand that she wanted a good, long holiday! Now I wish fondly that she may find Srinagar to her liking & our work of sufficient interest there too. Her advent ought to assure systematic progress & lighten the Baron's worries.[56]

Miss Lorimer appears to have settled in well at first, and Stein happily reports to the Allens:

The R.A. looks very fit indeed and assured me that she is *quite* comfortable at her *pension*. She has taken to riding though Srinagar offers just now no attractive mounts, and I hope to show her soon some of the interesting rides around the Dal, etc. I am glad to say my diplomatic endeavours promise to assure harmony in the work with the Baron.[57]

She has settled down now to work at the Collection in a business-like way & I hope things will move smoothly. The R.A. evidently enjoys the amenities of a social kind which Srinagar even in its winter sleep holds out, her Tennis, Badminton, etc. After this month, there will be plenty of little amusements further. In time she may appreciate the glorious views of the mountains, etc.[58]

She is keeping very fit, evidently appreciating what good things Kashmir can offer & is certainly well-pleased with her *pension* where she has congenial company, good care & a room with open views she much praises! I hope & wish she & the Good Baron may learn to appreciate each other's view of the work.[59]

However, it appears from the correspondence that Miss Lorimer did not find Andrews an easy colleague to work with. They had worked together on the Stein Collection in London for about four years until 1913, and after a six year break they were working together once again. In those years many things in Miss Lorimer's life had changed. She was now ten years older and in her mid-thirties. She had been working as the key person tidying up the Stein Collection in the British Museum, following all the preparatory work for the publication of *Serindia*. She had organised an exhibition of Stein's photographs (1913–16) which opened in the Royal Geographical Society on February 1st 1918.[60] She had lost her eldest brother in 1914, and had suffered a period of illness in 1917–18. The First World War had also brought many changes, and may well have thrown a new perspective on the pressures of Stein's constant long distance checking that things had been done properly. As the Secretary of the Royal Geographical Society was to write in 1919: "There are certain penalties attached to friendship with his great man [Stein], and I am sure you will pay them cheerfully.[61]

When Miss Lorimer arrived in Kashmir, Andrews was in the throes of arranging building work. The Kashmir Darbar had agreed to spend an extra 3,000 rupees on building an

[56] Bodleian Stein MS 16:18 Stein to Allen 26-02-19.
[57] Bodleian Stein MS 16:26 Stein to Allen 23-03-19.
[58] Bodleian Stein MS 16:38 Stein to Allen 16-05-19.
[59] Bodleian Stein MS 16:27 Stein to Allen 06-04-19.
[60] Royal Geographical Society Archives: Stein, M.A., RGS Correspondence, Block 1911–20, letter from Miss Lorimer to Secretary of RGS, 03-11-17.
[61] RGS: Stein. M. A. RGS Correspondence Block 1911–1920: RGS Secretary to Foster 29-05-19.

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annexe at the Andrews' new house to provide necessary working space,[62] but the building work seemed interminable. Stein writes:

> Unfortunately this [struggles with the Kashmiri workmen] renders the dear Baron rather sensitive to the changes which the R.A.'s advent necessarily implies in the work at the Collection. She herself looks quite fit & expresses herself well-pleased with the comforts which Miss O'Connor's Boarding House provides. I hope & wish she will recognize the need of showing consideration for the Bn's [Baron] experience & devoted zeal while at the same time helping *me* by her ways of putting things into methodical order. Of course, coming after 3 years work by the Bn she could scarcely expect to find a *tabula rasa*.[63]

Mirsky writes that Miss Lorimer "did not transplant well" and that her behaviour was "skittish",[64] but one of Stein's letters written two months after her arrival offers some explanation:

> She [R.A.] is keeping physically very fit, but shows an aptness of being v. critical of Indian things in general & our methods of work at the Collection in general. That the devoted Baron in spite of all his difficulties has catalogued a good portion of it already seems to cause disappointment, – as if we could have waited with the work. I hope she will settle down into our modest grooves & learn to appreciate what Kashmir can offer. Anyhow, it is a great comfort to feel that her uncertainty just a year ago gave us occasion to emphasise her complete freedom of decision.[65]

Miss Lorimer's disappointment is understandable. It was four years since her initial letter expressing enthusiasm for a transfer to Kashmir. She had spent the previous years preparing *Serindia* for publication, when Stein and Andrews had already moved away to begin work on the new Third Expedition. To arrive and find that two-thirds of the most interesting cataloguing work was already complete and that her task for three years might be little more than elaborate filing and adding in measurements can only have been frustrating. There was also a cholera epidemic in the area, which may have frightened her, particularly since she had only recently recovered from her own (unidentified) illness of 1917–18. Her criticisms of things Indian may have been the classic signs of culture shock; maybe some of Andrews' frustrations with the local builders were rubbing off on her. Walker writes that the Andrews were living more or less on a construction site at the Technical Institute,[66] and that this had become an obsession for them. Andrews was a perfectionist, making by hand the 30,000 tiles for the roof of the house, rarely allowing himself more than half a day away from the Institute compound, and ignoring his annual holiday entitlement.[67] In this context, he can hardly be described as an ideal working companion.

Stein's letter suggests that Miss Lorimer was tiring of the Stein project, that her enthusiasm may have been waning for some time. Walker writes that before her transfer to Kashmir, Miss Lorimer had been tempted by a position at the School of Oriental Studies.[68]

[62] Walker (1995), p. 234, 240.
[63] Quoted in Mirsky, p. 406.
[64] Mirsky, p. 406.
[65] Bodleian Stein MS 16:28 Stein to Allen 13-04-19.
[66] Andrews was Principal of the Amar Singh Technical Institute, Srinagar (Thacker's Indian Directory 1921).
[67] Walker (1995), p.240.
[68] Now the School of Oriental and African Studies, University of London. Walker (1995), p. 238.

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If she had been considering a change of career before deciding to go to Kashmir, the working conditions she found on arrival may well have been the last straw. No wonder then that she was eager to go home and stunned Stein by applying for a new job:

> The R.A. informed me of an official enquiry from Dr. Thomas on behalf of the I.O. whether she would wish to become an applicant for a Sub-Librarian's post to be newly created there, & also that she had despatched her application by last mail. The letter of T. was dated April 3rd, & from the way in which it was worded it seemed to me to amount practically to an offer of the appointment. As it is pensionable with a salary of £300 I should not for a moment have hesitated to recommend acceptance of it to the R.A.
>
> In reality, the *dénoûement* which must have been in preparation for some time, I believe, has brought welcome relief. Relatively short as the time is since the R.A. joined us, it has become pretty clear to both the Baron & myself that she did not care either for India or Kashmir, & still less for the work here. That necessity, not a real interest, had prevailed over her reluctance of last year I had not disguised to myself from the time when she at last decided to come out. But, for the distinct change on her ways, often irritable now & impatient over small things, I can account only by her illness of 1917–18. It was sad to realise how little she was able or willing to appreciate such pleasant aspects as Kashmir could offer; how completely her former keenness to see something of archaeology on the ground had disappeared, etc. Her great wish, as expressed in more than one way, was to get back to London & secure a permanent post. It is a comfort to feel that this is now likely to be achieved and in a way which removes all difficulty about her passage home. The I.O. which had sent her to help us here will be able to arrange this, too, without awkward questions from the Govt about the cost implied. The post is to become available by Aug, & probably by Nov the R.A. will be able to sail. Fortunately, the Baron's devotion had disposed of about 2/3 of the cataloguing work here, & perhaps, the happy prospect of her return will stimulate the R.A. to an effort to do her part also – instead of criticising his.[69]

Unfortunately, the posting fell through:

> Thomas, after conveying to her on the 3rd April an invitation from the Permanent Under Secretary of State to become a candidate for the Sub-Librarianship, had on the 10th instructions to inform her that the U.S. of S. having ascertained her engagement for 3 yrs' work here has decided to withdraw the enquiry. She still hopes to get her application accepted and has *now* asked me to intimate my approval & support by telegram & letter to the I.O. Of course, I have done my best for her, & wish it may be of some use. But I do not feel very hopeful, as offices do not generally like to go back on their blunders. In any case, I feel it will have the effect of further upsetting the poor R.A. She has changed strangely in various ways & seeing her unable to enjoy what advantages Kashmir & her present work can offer, I must wish that she may secure soon what she longs for at home. *All this, entre nous.*[70]

By the beginning of July 1919, while Miss Lorimer was waiting for news from the India Office, the cataloguing work on the Stein Collection was going well, and she took a short vacation from editing the slips, to go to Gulmarg "where she will find friends and society".[71]

[69] Bodleian Stein MS 16:38 Stein to Allen 16-05-19.
[70] Bodleian Stein MS 16:40 Stein to Allen 24-05-19.
[71] Bodleian Stein MS 16:49 Stein to Allen 02-07-19.

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This gave Stein a reprieve in which to consider Miss Lorimer and also the consequences of her possible departure from his Collection:

I was really comforted by what you wrote about the R.A. The war strain effect which you mention supplies an explanation for the change in her ways etc., better in every way than another which at one time forced itself upon my mind. You are only too right in what you say about an unwilling worker. With her knowledge of the former Collection she might have been a great help in supplementing the Baron's labours, the results of which need orderly arrangement in form & details. But what with want of interest & lassitude resulting from illness her work has been far less than one could hope for. A brief letter from Thomas received a fortnight ago mentioned the receipt of my cable and that it will relieve a serious difficulty about her I.O. appointment. This is quite satisfactory but confirms the impression the Baron & I had from the start, that the offer of the post was pre-arranged, probably before the R.A. started out, & that the subsequent withdrawal of it was merely the result of some one at the I.O. discovering too late the blunder which had been made in inviting the R.A.'s application before referring, as official etiquette – and common sense – demand, to the officer under whom she is employed. T. is a very excellent scholar but not very business-like. Hence all this muddle. For me it will be a relief to know the R.A. duly in a permanent appointment; for with her indifference to everything Indian and Indian archaeology in particular – the old desire to see arch. work in the field has vanished completely – there would be no hope to find a billet for her with Marshall.[72] I am glad she found Gulmarg to her liking during a holiday taken last month & will proceed there again on Aug. 8th. As to the rest – *vederemo* – To find a substitute will not be easy; for Indians with a serious interest in archaeol. work are difficult to find & the poor Baron after all his petty local worry dislikes & distrusts *all* Indians. Miss Walpole, who gave him temporary help before & whom he approved of, is quite as intelligent as the R.A. but has not had her college training & Museum experience.[73]

August brought more disappointments for Stein. He was aiming to finish the Third Report in the following 12–16 months, but foresaw problems: Andrews was preparing to move home, Miss Lorimer was "reluctant to do a full share", ready to leave as soon as the I.O. post was finalised. Stein was worried about the completion of the cataloguing work. By the end of the month, however, the situation had changed.

The R.A. had the disappointment of some man from Bodley [Bodleian Library, Oxford] being appointed to the I.O. post. We must wish that it will not affect her too much; but, I fear, it will not make work easier for her – or for the Baron either. I hope her friends at the Brit. Mus. & elsewhere may help her to another chance. What do her sisters think best for her?[74]

After this news, Miss Lorimer appears to have realised her lot and settled down.

The R.A. is now with a changed frame of mind enjoying her Kashmir life (I can scarcely add: the work too). She is physically v. flourishing. There can be no doubt that a permanent post at home would be the best thing for her, but she would prefer the offer of it *not* to come until after another year! Perhaps that mood may change again & not cause her to lose another chance at the I.O.[75]

[72] This was clearly a plan Stein had in mind for his colleagues. When his work on the Stein Collection was complete, Andrews became Assistant to Sir John Marshall [V&A Archives, India: Archaeology Survey, V&A Minutes 02-07-23].

[73] Bodleian Stein MS 16:51 Stein to Allen 16-07-19.

[74] Bodleian Stein MS 16:61 Stein to Allen 26-08-19.

[75] Bodleian Stein MS 16:93 Stein to Allen 25-11-19.

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The changed frame of mind also coincides with the period when Andrews had gone to work on the collection in New Delhi, when she would have been left to get on with her work alone in Srinagar.

Mirsky's comment that "The Recording Angel, when finally she came to Srinagar after the war, did not transplant well,"[76] may accurately reflect the case initially, but despite the uneasy beginnings of her three year position in Kashmir, Miss Lorimer remained there for the full period of her employment, leaving for England in early November 1922. In fact, Miss Lorimer (rather than the Recording Angel) appears to have enjoyed her life there:

The R.A. will leave next week. That she enjoyed her 'good time' here is a comfort, & that she took her work not too seriously during these years I shall quickly forget. May she find her paths at home so smooth, too![77]

Miss Lorimer's departure from Kashmir marked the end of a long association with the Stein Collection. She had started working on the Stein Collection in 1909, and worked on the Collection and publications for a total of thirteen years: nine years in the British Museum, and four years in Kashmir. Her departure also marked a disappearance from the oriental world. Despite her first-hand experience in oriental and Central Asian antiquities, she wrote nothing related to these fields other than her contributions published in Stein's reports.

Back to Britain

As Stein recognised in 1909 when he was so eager to employ her on his Collection, Miss Lorimer was an intelligent and efficient woman. By the time she finished working with Stein and returned to Britain in 1923 she was nearing forty. She had spent the last thirteen years working in a specialised field, and then abandoned it. From the records that remain, it would appear that contrary to the conjecture by Mirsky and Walker, Miss Lorimer had in fact enjoyed her life in Kashmir, for within two years she was on her way back there, having joined the buying team at a department store in Chelsea.

Back in Britain, Miss Lorimer took up the position of Secretary to Lord Shuttleworth, Lord-Lieutenant of Lancashire and President of the County Territorial Association (1908–28).[78] She was also looking for more appropriate work. In November 1923, her former colleague, Laurence Binyon (1869–1943), Keeper of Prints and Drawings at the British Museum, wrote to William Bateson (1861–1926), the first Director of the newly established John Innes Horticultural Institution:

I write chiefly to ask if you think seriously about Miss Lorimer. I have had a long letter from her. She is now Secry [Secretary] to Ld Shuttleworth up in Westmorland & fearfully bored by the dullness of the work. She is thinking of applying for a post in connection with the Oriental part of the Wembley Exhibition[79] next year; also has an eye on Sotheby's should Edmunds retire. But those are only possibilities, & the first only temporary. She is free to accept any post if one is offered. I don't know

[76] Mirsky, pp. 406–7.
[77] Bodleian Stein MS 16:83 Stein to Allen 28-10-22.
[78] *Who was Who, 1929–40.*
[79] Wembley Stadium, originally known as the Empire Stadium, was built as the centre-piece of the British Empire Exhibition of 1924.

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what she would say to yours, or whether she would be *quite* what you want, but she has done a big job for Stein really well - over a number of years – & we all here would like her to get something of the kind she wants, knowing her work to be good. Her present address (should you think of opening negotiations) is: Miss F. Lorimer, Barbon Manor, Kirkby Lonsdale, Westmorland.[80]

Before the year was out, Miss Lorimer was Librarian-Registrar at the John Innes Horticultural Institution.[81] She stayed at the Institution for over a year, and whilst no doubt doing an excellent job, apparently irritated Bateson. In a personal letter to his wife, Beatrice, written on board a ship, on a trip to or from Denmark, he continues an ongoing private joke:

The Florence Warden[82] book struck me as a record for inanity, but I have already found its match, if not its master. At L'pool St. I saw *a row* of novels by 'Norma Lorimer' and out of curiosity I bought 'Cathering Sterling' in its *50th* thousand. I am almost convinced that the family hand is there. There is the same flavour of perfect competence and sufficiency, the same medley of scraps of knowledge imbedded [*sic*] in a matrix of ignorance and conceit from which we suffer. In supremest moments the characters interject explanatory remarks and notes from Baedekker, tags from any and everything, which Ouida would have scorned. The heroine, being about to embark on a career of free love, remarks (twice over) in utmost solemnity that she does wish she could have had 'benefit of clergy'!! I do blame the publisher a little but I daresay he knows what his readers like . . .[83]

This was a private letter, clearly intended solely for his wife's amusement, however, Miss Lorimer's departure from the Institution may have been a relief for both of them.

Back at the British Museum, there was a new assistant working on the Stein Collection, "Miss Joan Joshua, who has since 1924, acted as assistant to Sir Aurel Stein in various literary and artistic capacities in connection with the publication of *Innermost Asia*." Miss Joshua was associated with the Collection for some years, and did the "restoring and mounting" of the textiles from Loulan and Astana for the exhibition at India House from March 24th to May 2nd 1931.[84] Miss Lorimer was clearly no longer associated with the Stein Collection.

On March 1st 1925, two years after leaving Kashmir, Miss Lorimer joined the buying team at the Peter Jones store in Chelsea.[85] Initially, she was employed as a "subsidiary" buyer, appointed on a more or less experimental basis with the intention that she should undertake a journey to the Far East in order to buy "carpets and other goods on the frontiers of India and at other points at which one or more Asiatic as well as European middle-men would be cut out." As it would be an experimental project, the Chairman of Peter Jones, Mr John Spedan Lewis (1885–1963), undertook to defray the costs personally although he was optimistic that it would be profitable business for the Company. The John Lewis Archives note that Miss Lorimer was "already an acknowledged authority on oriental

[80] John Innes Centre Archives, Binyon to Bateson 15-11-23.

[81] Bateson was, from 1910, the first Director of the newly established John Innes Horticultural Institution.

[82] Florence Warden [pseudonym of Florence Alice Price, afterwards James] was author of over 190 popular titles.

[83] Norma Lorimer was another popular novelist; *Catherine Sterling* (1903) is one of 30 titles (*Who was Who, 1929–40*).

[84] V&A File Stein, M. R. Dr.: typed notice 09-04-31; also Stein to Wace, Keeper of Textiles 13-02-25. See also *Innermost Asia*, Introduction p. xx: "useful assistance was rendered by Miss J. Joshua with regard to the verification of all references, whether to Descriptive Lists, Plates, &c., or to other publications."

[85] John Lewis Partnership Archives.

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artefacts with an especial interest in rugs". Her introduction to the Partnership was almost certainly effected by the Chairman's wife, Sarah Beatrice Mary (née Hunter) (1890–1953), also a Somerville graduate (1909–12), and herself a buyer at Messrs Peter Jones 1922–3, before she married the Chairman in 1923.[86]

The advance planning for the journey shows that Miss Lorimer was intending to visit the Punjab, Peshawar, Quetta, Kashmir, Madras, Baroda and the United Provinces. There is also a later reference to some photographs she had taken (sadly, no longer extant) which indicates that she also went to the borders of Afghanistan. The merchandise that she planned to purchase included Numdah rugs, gubbas [long-sleeved robes], bedspreads, sandalwood and lacquer boxes, brassware, semi-precious stones, small wooden curios and tables, Peshawar rugs, papier mâché, silk tweed fabrics and shawls, and furs, the latter only to be considered with caution.

Mr Lewis is renowned, like Mr Nicholson of the Bodleian, for having been keen to employ educated young women, but in the case of Miss Lorimer, there was also a hidden agenda. Mr Lewis owned an aviary, and he was willing to commission Miss Lorimer to make private purchases of owls and humming birds for his collection. On a later occasion, he said "Miss Lorimer is a genuine enthusiast for birds and spends a good deal of her time in bird watching and visiting sanctuaries."[87]

According to the John Lewis archives she prepared for the trip exhaustively, making contacts in the wholesale and retail trade and taking specialist advice on things like precious stones. She must have left England by the end of July 1925. By November, the first instalment of her purchases was expected in Peter Jones and a special area on the ground floor of the store was to be prepared for their display. By April 1926 she was back in England and was instructed to offer things which she had purchased in India to any interested museums or connoisseurs.

By 1926 Miss Lorimer had a more specific position, Buyer of Foreign Carpets, and was offered this position on a permanent basis. The John Lewis archives suggest this was possibly a reaction to the fact that she had just been offered a position on the staff of the British Museum, though there is no evidence to support this in the British Museum archives. The 1929 Census of the John Lewis Partnership [by then there had been an amalgamation of Peter Jones with the John Lewis store on Oxford Street] describes her as Buyer of Oriental Carpets and Oriental Fancy Goods. Further buying trips were planned for 1927 and 1928. The first was cancelled and it is not known if the second ever took place. She had a period of ill-health in 1931 and by April 1932 she had left the John Lewis Partnership.

It was during these seven years with John Lewis that she married, at the age of forty-five, on December 18th 1928 Mr Arthur Cardew (d. 1936), a retired civil servant and widower of three years. Strangely, the box marking her "Rank or Profession" on the marriage certificate has a line drawn across it. The marriage took place in the parish of St Bartholomew the Great, London, although neither of them lived near the church [she was living in Kensington; he in Wimbledon], and both gave their residence at the time of

[86] *Somerville College Register 1879–1971*.

[87] Ornithology may have been a Lorimer family interest. Her sister, Hilda, is also known to have had a keen interest. Somerville Archives, Craig to Deputy Secretary, The University, Dundee 05-05-69.

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marriage as Church House, Cloth Fair, EC1, a "suitcase" address probably for 15 days prior to the marriage. There is no obvious explanation for this location; it may be simply that they wished to marry there. The two witnesses were Miss Lorimer's mother, Isabella, now a widow of seventy-nine, and Sylvia Farnell, youngest sister of Arthur Cardew, and wife of Lewis Farnell (1856–1934), Rector of Exeter College, Oxford.[88]

Miss Lorimer and Mr Cardew had several things in common: both had Scottish ancestry (Cardew's father was a Captain in the 74th Highlanders). Both came from successful academic families, with close associations at Oxford. One of Cardew's sons, the potter Michael Cardew (1901–83), when describing his own student days at Oxford wrote: "Did I also give any weight to the reflection that for at least four generations some direct ancestor had studied or taught at Oxford, starting in the eighteenth century with the semi-mythical Dr Cornelius Cardew, D.D., of Liskeard and Truro?"[89] There were also strong ties with India. Miss Lorimer and her siblings were notable figures in that sphere, and one of Cardew's sons was resident in India.[90]

Both Miss Lorimer and Mr Cardew had abandoned, apparently voluntarily, successful careers and changed track completely. Miss Lorimer no longer worked with the celebrated academics associated with Sir Aurel Stein and his collections. Mr Cardew had turned his back on a legal career to go into the antiques trade, which is where, the family story goes, he met Miss Lorimer. Their Oxford connections may have brought them together.

Miss Lorimer, now Mrs Cardew, went to live in Arthur Cardew's house in North View, Wimbledon Common. It was the family house where Mr Cardew had lived with his first wife Alexandra, their six children, a nanny and three maids, and was crammed with antique furniture, china and music. Arthur Cardew was an amateur violinist who loved Corelli, Haydn and Mozart beyond all other music,[91] and one of his grandsons, Cornelius Cardew (b. 1936), became a professional musician.

In 1931, Mrs Cardew's mother died in Bournemouth at the age of 81. Mrs Cardew's period of ill-health at John Lewis in 1931 may have been associated with her mother's death. Whether this is coincidence or not, the following year she left her job at the John Lewis Partnership, and made another career move, this time away from the commercial world back to the academic world.

On Monday 14th October 1932 she took over the duties of Assistant Librarian at the Royal Asiatic Society, which was then preparing a Library Author Catalogue, funded by the Carnegie United Kingdom Trust.[92] By coincidence she joined the Royal Asiatic Society in the same year that Sir Aurel Stein was awarded the Society's Triennial Gold Medal, in recognition of his distinguished services in oriental research.[93]

[88] Marriage certificate.

[89] Michael Cardew: *A Pioneer Potter* (1989), p. 20.

[90] Cardew's son, Christopher George Cardew, was resident in India. See Arthur Cardew's will of 10-06-31.

[91] Cardew, op. cit., p. 1, p. 153. Cardew's violin ["my violin by Antonius son of Andreas Amati, with the case containing it and the violin bow by Lupet and the viola bow therein also contained"] was clearly a treasured possession; special mention of it was made in his will (10-06-31).

[92] "The post [of Assistant Librarian] is now held by Mrs Arthur Cardew (formerly Miss F. M. G. Lorimer), who will be known to many members for her knowledge of Oriental matters. Mrs Cardew was on the staff of the Bodleian and was Assistant to Sir Aurel Stein for thirteen years, nine at the British Museum and four in India. She has been engaged in Oriental work for some twenty years." JRAS Anniversary Meeting, *JRAS*, 1933, p. 729.

[93] *Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society*, 1932.

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Within a month, Mrs Cardew had submitted to the RAS Library Committee certain suggestions in connection with proofs of the Library Catalogue, and by March 1934 about one eighth of the entries had been proofed.[94] The Society's minutes over the eight years from 1932 to 1940 detail the progress on the Library Catalogue: in January 1938 Mrs Cardew was engaged "on Mu, and would finish the letter M by the end of the month. She explained that it covered a long series of volumes and that she had also finished various other Series which she had met in connection with M, such as *Mémoires; Soc. Finno-Ougr., Selections from the Records of the Govt. of Bombay and Madras, Mus. Guimet; Bibl. de Vulgarisation*, and all books from shelf 104B, behind the Secretary's table."[95]

Back in the academic world, she was once again working among familiar faces: by 1935 her brother Lock was recommended for a position on the Council of the Society, and her old colleague and Keeper of the Department of Oriental Books and Manuscripts at the British Museum, Lionel Barnett (1871–1960), was on the Library Committee.

But the Second World War forced the Royal Asiatic Society to consider its future. A Ways and Means Committee was set up, which in June 1940 "regretfully recommended to Council as a means of carrying the society through the war years that notice should be given to the Secretary and Assistant Librarian, terminating their services in September, with liberty to resign at any time." In the meantime, Mrs Cardew was instructed to make a list of books to be sent away to safety from the war: the books, packed by Professor Edwards, were sent to Dawlish in Devon, and the boxes of manuscripts which had been stored in Lloyds Bank, St James Street were sent to Swallowfield in Hampshire.[96]

Not long after the war started Mrs Cardew, now a widow since her husband's death in 1936,[97] had written to her earlier colleague, Mr Gibson, at the Bodleian:

I am in Oxford for a few days with my sister, and wonder if I could see you for a few minutes on business?

Pencil notes on the letter reveal:

She was a member of the old Cat. Rev. Staff. Very efficient & a pleasant person to work with. She might be employed (for duration) on Gen. Libr. duties.[98]

One of Gibson's letters of April 1940 reveals the uncertainty of the time:

At present Librarians and Assistant Librarians (over 30) are exempt from military service. If this stands several of those we expected to lose will remain. On the other hand, if we are expected to take the offensive in 1942 (P.M.'s speech) I should suppose that every man (20–40) will be wanted before long. At the moment, however, there are no temporary vacancies; you shall be informed at once of new developments.[99]

By February 1941 Mrs Cardew had a new job in Cambridge, and wrote to Gibson:

[94] RAS, Library Committee, Minutes of Proceedings of Council 20-03-34.

[95] RAS, Library Committee, Minutes of Proceedings of Council 20-01-38.

[96] RAS Minutes of Proceedings of Council 09-01-41 and 13-02-41. Evangeline Dora Edwards (1888–1957), Professor of Chinese, University of London (SOAS) was then Honorary Secretary of the Royal Asiatic Society.

[97] Arthur Cardew had arranged for his widow to receive £1,000 upon his death, and "a yearly sum of one hundred & fifty pounds to be paid quarterly during her life" (Cardew's will, 10-06-31).

[98] Bodleian Archives, Cardew to Gibson 28-12-39.

[99] Bodleian Archives, Gibson to Cardew 17-07-40.

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I want just to send you my address so that I may not get out of touch with the Bodleian. I have been here nearly 2 months now, taking the place of a man who has gone to the Army, in Heffer's (Secondhand Oriental Dept.)! But I don't know how long it may last, as that, of course, depends on whether trade keeps up or not.[100]

She did not stay in Cambridge long. At a Council Meeting of the Royal Horticultural Society on January 6th 1941 Mrs Cardew was named as Acting Librarian for the Society, while the Librarian, William Stearn (b. 1911), joined the Royal Air Force. Stearn was then not quite thirty; Mrs Cardew was in her late fifties. Professor Stearn remembers her as

my assistant librarian at the Lindley Library and engaged to recatalogue its holdings; I joined the Royal Air Force and she took charge of the Lindley Library until I returned in 1946 ... She was certainly a well-educated, highly intelligent, scholarly and strong-minded woman acquainted with Ancient Greek, Latin, French and German ... She spent most of her life in association with distinguished men she could respect and who respected her ... Mrs Cardew, I suspect, preferred working with men to working with women. After I left the Lindley Library in 1952 for a scientific post and was replaced by a woman, relations in the Library, rudely called then 'The Hen Roost' by other members of the R.H.S. staff, relations there do not seem to have been as harmonious as before and Mrs Cardew resigned or retired. I remember her telling me that he [Stein] thought the heavenly 'soma' drink of Aryan mythology in India was dimly remembered rhubarb wine![101]

From 1952 Mrs Cardew was working on the catalogue for the exhibition marking the 150th anniversary celebrations of the Royal Horticultural Society, *The Royal Horticultural Society 1804–1954: Exhibition of Manuscripts, Books, Drawings, Portraits, Medals and Congratulatory Addresses. On the occasion of the Society's 150th anniversary celebration 1954*, a short volume of 64 pages.[102]

It is not known when Mrs Cardew stopped working at the Society, but since she joined the Society for the Bibliography of Natural History in 1957 and her name is included on the Society's membership list of 1963, the year she was 80, she surely maintained an interest in the subject after her retirement. The only publications written solely in her name are those pertaining to natural history, the longest only five pages. These were all published in the *Journal of the Royal Horticultural Society*: "John Abercrombie (1726–1806)",[103] "Dr Thornton and the 'New Illustration' 1799–1807",[104] Dr Thornton's Royal Botanical Lottery, 1811",[105] "A note on the illustration of roses"[106] L.S.A.I.D.A. A riddle of horticultural authorship",[107], "A note on Poiret and Turpin's 'Leçons de Flore' ".[108] There is also an unpublished typescript "Report on the 3 classified albums of *Reeve's Drawings* (Camellias, Chrys, Peonies) bought from Heywood Hill".[109]

[100] Bodleian Archives, Cardew to Gibson 07-04-41.
[101] Letter to the author, 15-04-94.
[102] Foreword by President D. Bowes Lyon: "On behalf of the Council I wish to express our gratitude to DR GEORGE TAYLOR and MRS F. CARDEW who have largely been responsible for the compilation of this brochure."
[103] *JHRS*, LXXII (1947), part 6, pp. 245–8.
[104] *JHRS*, LXXII (1947), part 7, pp. 281–5.
[105] *JHRS*, LXXII (1947), part 11, pp. 450–3.
[106] *JHRS*, LXXIII (1948), part 6, pp. 180–2.
[107] *JHRS*, LXIV (1949), part 6, pp. 256–61.
[108] *JHRS*, LXXVIII (1953), part 8, pp. 293–4.
[109] In the Lindley Library, Royal Horticultural Society (1953).

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Mrs Cardew died on February 15th 1967. She had been suffering from Parkinson's Disease and had grown very bent in the back. She told her brother Bertie, who true to his campaigning spirit insisted on visiting her at least once a year from Scotland, that it was such a long way to come; she was content to sit in the chair by the window and watch the clouds. A woman came daily to help her, but eventually she grew too ill, and needed more care. Within days of moving out of her own home, she died of bronchopneumonia. Her niece, Mrs Jean Dunlop, informed the Sutton Registrar that day. Sadly, once again, "occupation unknown" was recorded for the family's much-loved Aunt Floss.[110]

But Miss Lorimer had several occupations during her lifetime, sometimes filling posts traditionally held by men, and she earned the respect of the scholars she worked with. Her contribution to the academic world remains in use today, though it is mostly regarded as anonymous, in the form of Stein's Reports and the various library catalogues.

[110] From the conversations with the Lorimer family and Mrs Dunlop; also from the death certificate.

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